Wings 3D and the GIMP

Quickly Modelling and Texturing an Airplane

For those of you who are artists, and eager to get into 3D art but lack the resources to get high-end packages like Maya, Max, Softimage, Houdini, LightWave, etc, here is a launchpad! Wings 3D, a subdivision modeller inspired by Nendo and Mirai from Izware, has served thousands of artists across the globe as a dedicated 3D modeller. This series of articles demonstrates how you can use Wings 3D to create a model of an airplane.

If you have access to the Net, just visit the website (wings3d.com), and download a suitable version for your platform. For hardcore Linux fans, it's easier—either use ArtistX (a customised version of Ubuntu 8.10) or the Knoppix 5.3.1 live DVD; both these distros have Wings 3D installed and preconfigured. If you use another distro, try the package manager (Synaptic for Debian and derivatives, RPM or Yum for Red Hat and its derivatives). Mark the Wings 3D package for installation, and once installed, fire it up from the terminal.

Figure 1 shows a thumbnail of the result of our design, so you know what we are working to achieve.

You might find the GUI unusual—Figure 2 shows what the default screen of Wings 3D looks like once you fire it up. Unlike other high-end 3D applications, you do not have the screen split into 4 views. But that does not prevent Wings 3D from being a great subdivision sur*face* modeller. The four cubes that you observe on the centre top are the four selection modes: vertices selection, edge selection, face selection and object selection. You can customise the mouse function under *Edit>Preferences*, to resemble other high-end applications that you may be used to. Just like in Maya, you also have an outliner under the *Window* menu, which provides a list of all objects in the scene, stacked in order of their creation, and linked to each other.

Frequently used keyboard short-cuts

Novice artists will get stuck if not conversant with the various keyboard short-cuts, particularly in applications like Wings 3D and Blender. See Tables 1 to 4 for brief descriptions of the various